

הקדוש ברוך הוא is a פרשה which has something to teach us about the כח of תפילה. We know that משה רבינו was angry at כלל ישראל because of the חטא העגל, but ultimately, He wanted us to become better. כפרה davened on our behalf for פרשה. Two of the words that R' Chaim Kanievsky highlights are רחום והנון. רחום wants to have רחמנות on us. He wants to be kind, gracious, and generous to us. Therefore, He gives us the opportunity to daven.

There is a fascinating story in R' Chaim's sefer about Rebbetzin Kanievsky's father R' Elyashiv זצ"ל. She relates that when she was a little girl, about ten years old, after R' Elyashiv would finish שמונה עשרה, he would take three steps back and stand there for a period of time. She once asked him what he was saying. He told her that before finishing the רצון יהי at the end of שמונה עשרה, he would recite פרק קכ"א, which begins גאון אשכנזי אל ההרים שיר למעלות. Why did he do this? R' Elyashiv's grandfather was a famous and well known in his own right. The לשם told R' Elyashiv that saying this פרק was a סגולה for certain things. R' Elyashiv said that he loved סגולות [which is fascinating to hear from a Litvak, that he believed in סגולות], so he said this קאפיטל, despite not knowing why.

Many years later, Rebbetzin Kanievsky's son-in-law told her an interesting story. In the חבורון of ישיבה, there was a group of twenty בחורים who had been eligible for marriage for years but had not been able to find their שידוך. One day, they came across an obscure sefer. It turned out to be from the מפאנו [this is where I first heard about it years ago from Rabbi Oelbaum]. The sefer stated that reciting פרק קכ"א at the end of שמונה עשרה is a סגולה for finding a שידוך. [This is in the מפאנו, מאמר חקור דין, רמ"ע מפאנו, part 4, חלק י"ז.] These twenty בחורים adopted the מנהג, and within two months, each one of them had found a שידוך. This is interesting because I also say a few פרקים of תהילים after שמונה עשרה. I don't usually share my מנהגים, as I don't want people to feel obligated to follow them, but it is always fascinating to learn about the מנהגים of earlier generations, which I now have become. Over the years, I have personally adopted the practice of saying three פרקים of תהילים after שמונה עשרה. R' Chaim writes in his ספר that there is a מנהג to say ק"ל as well, so I recite ק"ל, קכ"א, and also מזמור לתודה. I thank Hashem for all His goodness and kindness, even though I already say it in שחרית. But I add it to my שמונה עשרה as well. It makes me daven longer and later, and I have trouble keeping up to get קדושה on time, but I manage to get it done.

Now, on a completely separate topic, since this year שבת כי תשא is smack dab in the middle of פורים, I want to refer back to a previous דבר תורה I shared and add a קנייט from R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld that I think you will find interesting. As we all know, this week's פרשה discusses two things, קטורת and שמן המשחה. In the קטורת it says (30:23) - וְאַתָּה קַח לָךְ בְּשָׂמִים רִאשׁוֹן מִן הַמִּטְרִיף - You should take the best, the nicest of the spices, and that is מִן הַמִּטְרִף - מִן הַמִּטְרִף - pure מִן הַמִּטְרִף. מִן is supposed to be the number one most beautiful spice that was used in the קטורת, and which was apparently known to those people at that time. As we have mentioned, מִן הַמִּטְרִף translates מִן הַמִּטְרִף as מִן הַמִּטְרִף, which has almost identical letters as מִן הַמִּטְרִף. This shows that the צדיקים are compared to the most beautiful spices, which is brought down in the גמרא - אנשי כנסת הגדולה ראש וראשון was מִן הַמִּטְרִף. גדול הדור. Now, here's something fascinating. R' Chaim adds another insight. While discussing the קטורת, he asks, "Where do we find מִן הַמִּטְרִף in all of these items?" And guess what? The word for חלבנה in the קטורת, that's the crummy smelling spice. What is the גימטריה for חלבנה? Look it up. It's 95. Guess what the גימטריה for מִן הַמִּטְרִף is? 95. So we know that it's a bitter, horrible, terrible spice, which is included in the קטורת to teach us that we have to have רחמנות and everybody in כלל ישראל and include them in our עבודה just like the ערבה in the מינים, but we certainly don't have to have רחמנות for מִן הַמִּטְרִף.

May all of עמלק be destroyed in this זכות of our keeping this טוב of פורים, may we see the immediate and quick downfall of all of the עמלקים in this world, including the עמלק that's within each and every one of us. In that זכות, we shall see the אמן במהרה בימינו.

